NEWSLETTER REVIEW

List health and engagement plan



A mailing list is like a garden!!

Our mailing list is alive. Leave it alone and it fills with weeds: dead addresses and people who never read. Look after it and it blooms. So, we treat it like a garden and nurture it.

Weed

Clear out dead and silent contacts.

Water

Send emails worth opening.

Grow

Welcome new, willing readers.

WHERE WE ARE

The newsletter is performing well

7.9%

Average click rate, July to September

Up from 4.4% in January.

0.96%

Bounce rate, September

The share of emails that could not be delivered, such as dead addresses. Down from 5.6% in October 2025.

26 to 47%

Open rate range across 12 sends

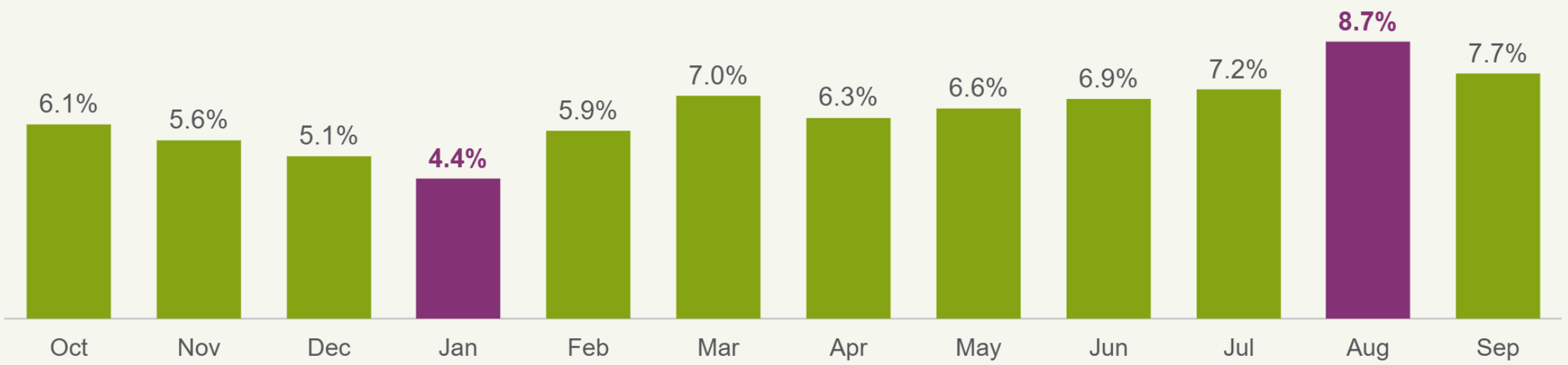
Which stacks up well against a Non-profit benchmark of around 35%

Opens are inflated by Apple Mail Privacy Protection, so we judge success on clicks.

Source: Mailchimp campaign reports, October 2025 to September 2026

WHERE WE ARE

Click rate by send



Lowest in January (4.4%), highest in August (8.7%). Clicks per open rose from about 14% to about 26% over the same period.

Source: Mailchimp campaign reports, October 2025 to September 2026

THE LIST

About 1 in 3 subscribers has ever clicked a link



419 of 1,311 subscribers, excluding Hutton staff. Each month’s clicks come from between 61 and 117 people, so the engaged core is small and loyal.

Source: Mailchimp audience and segment exports, 16 October 2026

THE LIST

The garden map

Group	Contacts	Share	What we do
Engaged core (the blooms)	295	22%	Keep happy, use for subject line tests
Quiet readers (the seedlings)	671	50%	Open but never click: nudge with better content
Lapsed clickers (the wilting ones)	93	7%	Clicked before, quiet now: a “we’ve missed you” email
Never opened (the weeds)	153	11%	The weeds: re-permission email, then archive the silent
New joiners (new seeds)	99	7%	Joined since 15 October 2025: welcome them, judge later
Internal staff (the greenhouse)	44	3%	Segment out of reporting

Every subscriber sits in exactly one group: 1,355 in total.

Source: Mailchimp audience and segment exports, 16 October 2026

THE PLAN: WEEDING

The clean-up in four steps



1

Protect

Leave new joiners (99) and staff (44) out of the clean-up.

2

Ask

Send the 153 never-opened contacts a “still want to hear from us?” email, with a follow-up a week later.

3

Confirm

Count only a click on “Yes, keep me subscribed”. Opens do not count, because Apple inflates them.

4

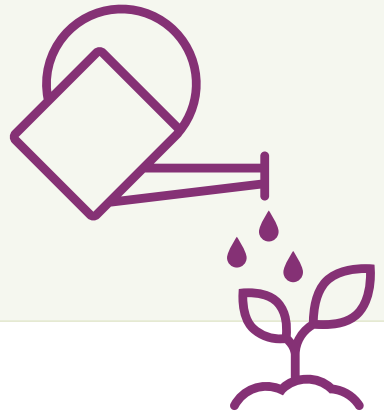
Archive

After about three weeks, archive anyone who has not clicked. Archive rather than delete, so the history stays.

The list shrinks by 153 at most. Sender reputation and reporting both improve.

THE PLAN: WATERING

What the emails tell us



Fix now

- A WordPress admin link took 24.9% of March clicks, and readers would hit a login page.
- About a dozen Bing redirect links sit in the June and August issues. Swap them for clean URLs.
- Every subject line reads “News from the Hutton [Month] Newsletter”.
- Social icons get 0 to 1% of clicks, and stories carry two links each – one in picture, one in button.

Keep doing

- Video links were among the top five links in six of the 12 issues.
- Events and research stories pull well: the lecture links took about 20% of September clicks.
- Commercial content works at the bottom: the Deep Time whisky link led August.
- Long issues still get clicks near the end, so length is not the problem.

Source: Mailchimp campaign reports and click maps, October 2025 to September 2026

THE PLAN: GROWING

Six ideas to win more clicks



Better seed

Lead subject lines with the story, and A/B test one every month.

A regular rhythm

Pick one send slot, then test mornings against late afternoons.

A second chance

Resend to non-openers a few days later. The May resend won 134 opens and 23 clicks.

Different beds

Interest segments: events, policy, farming and industry, research.

Show, don’t tell

Make a 60-second video the lead story, since video links already do well.

Spread the pollen

Add a “forward to a colleague” nudge. Forwards are zero on every send.

Source: Mailchimp campaign reports and click maps, October 2025 to September 2026

NEXT STEPS

The to-do list



Tend the garden

- Six **Action segments** have been created to help with nurturing going forward. Keep **Action 6** (Internal staff) out of reporting.
- Write the “still want to hear from us?” email for **Action 4** (Never opened), with a “Yes, keep me subscribed” button and a reminder a week later.
- After about three weeks, archive the **Action 4** contacts who have not clicked.
- Write a “we’ve missed you” email for **Action 2** (Lapsed clickers).
- Send a welcome email to **Action 5** (New joiners).
- Nudge **Action 3** (Quiet readers) with click-led subject lines, tested first on **Action 1** (Engaged core).

Help it grow

- Fix the email issues: the WordPress admin link, the Bing links and try a ‘Follow us on LinkedIn for more’ rather than a row of social icons.
- Agree one send slot and start monthly subject line tests.
- Resend each issue to non-openers a few days later.
- Agree targets for click rate, bounces and unsubscribes.
- **Brainstorm together:** how do we bring in new, willing readers?

Action 1 to 6 are the segments set up in Mailchimp. The garden map slide explains each one.